Both inscriptions stated that a Pandyan king named Netuncaliyan had ordered the rectangular beds to be cut into the floor of the cave as a donation for Nanta-siri Kuvan, head of the Jain monks. ‘The two inscriptions,’ wrote Mahadevan, ‘are the oldest historical records in Tamil discovered so far. Their archaic linguistic and palaeographic features indicate a date around the second century BC.’ This matched the finding of Mahadevan’s colleague K. A. N. Sastri, who placed Raja Netuncaliyan in about 160 BCE as a contemporary of the Chera king Senguttuvan. The Sangam literary work *Mathuraikkanci*, written to extol his virtues, had credited him with winning a battle against an Arya army from the North.

Thanks to Mahadevan and his colleagues, many more Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions were either discovered or reinterpreted over the next four decades, ranging in date from the second century BCE to the fourth century BCE. Mahadevan’s direct involvement ended in 2000 but he continues to keep in touch with developments, and in a recent newspaper interview he lamented the damage being inflicted on these precious early inscriptions by ignorant tourists and quarriers: ‘Already in my lifetime many Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions have been lost or damaged severely. The destruction is now proceeding much faster. It is sad that the public are indifferent and the State and Central Governments helpless to stop this wanton destruction of our cultural heritage. I can only shed tears at what has been lost and, frankly, I am not hopeful that what remains will be saved.’[23]

More than ninety Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions from over thirty cave-sites have so far been identified in Tamil Nadu and Kerala, of which all but five are directly associated with Jain retreats. They show that over a period of some five hundred years Chera and Pandya rulers, as well as local mercantile communities, supported the Jain monks and nuns